

Local Structures and the Embeddedness of Transnational Organised Crime in European Cities

RIMC08: Where the local meets the global

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1. Introduction

Local urban characteristics are powerful predictors of crime. In Barcelona, indicators of urban opportunity structures, including tourism infrastructure and density of informal economies are strongly correlated with theft and assault (Kim et al., 2025). However, this finding raises a more complex and critical question: Do these same local characteristics also function as the operational infrastructure for transnational organised crime (TOC)? The connection is far from simple. Unlike opportunistic street crime, TOC involves sophisticated global networks that penetrate, exploit, and embed themselves within specific local contexts.

The academic literature has often focused on the networks themselves, yet, as Cooke (1988) critically explained, “we are not only without an adequate cartography of global capitalism but also lack political maps of our own backyards” (Hobbs, 1998). This “glocal” gap in understanding how global crime manifests in our specific neighbourhoods—is the central problem this paper seeks to address. The concept of *glocalisation*, introduced by Robertson (2012), captures precisely this dynamic: the simultaneous processes of globalisation and localisation that define contemporary organised crime. Building on this concept, Van de Bunt, Siegel and Zaitch (2014) argue that criminal organisations are not operating in a social vacuum; instead, they are socially and spatially embedded within their local environments, exploiting resources, relationships and opportunities that circulate within those territorial contexts.

Against this background, this paper uses a systematic literature review to answer the following research question: **How do local opportunity structures facilitate the social and economic embeddedness of transnational organised crime in European cities?**

This paper employs glocalisation as its primary analytical lens, operationalised through social (relational ties enabling trust and cooperation in illicit operations) and economic (exploitation of legitimate market structures for criminal purposes) embeddedness. A systematic literature review is particularly suited because empirical evidence on TOC embeddedness is fragmented across disparate case studies, disciplines and national contexts. By synthesising this dispersed literature, the review can identify cross-cutting mechanisms that individual studies cannot capture, while also revealing geographic and thematic gaps in current knowledge. This paper shows that these opportunity structures

form an interactive system. The analysis shows that macro-level vulnerabilities (e.g. economic disparities, weak border policies) create the supply of victims and incentives for illicit finance, which are then operationally exploited by meso-level infrastructures such as tourism facilities, informal labour markets, and weakly regulated urban spaces. Understanding these dynamics is urgent: the EU Anti-Trafficking Coordinator (2024) estimates over 7,000 registered victims annually, while exploitation in the tourism and hospitality sectors undermines labour rights and urban safety for residents and migrants alike.

The structure of this paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 outlines the methodology; Section 3 presents findings organised by macro-, meso-, and micro-level opportunity structures; and Section 4 concludes with implications for research and policy.

2. Methodology

This paper employs a systematic literature review to synthesise existing empirical and policy-oriented research on the interactions between tourism, migrant demographics, informal economies, and surveillance gaps in facilitating TOC in European cities.

Searches were conducted across Scopus, JSTOR and Google Scholar, using keywords related to the research question. The primary search string is the following: ("human trafficking" OR "labour trafficking" OR "sex trafficking" OR "money laundering" OR "transnational organised crime") AND ("tourism" OR "hotel*" OR "hospitality" OR "migrat*" OR "short-term rental*") AND ("urban" OR "city" OR "district*" OR "neighbourhood*")

The search yielded approximately 30,083 results, of which 88 met the inclusion criteria, and 23 were ultimately selected; the remaining were excluded as they addressed TOC at a regional scale without attention to urban-level structures. Inclusion criteria specified English and Spanish languages, peer-reviewed papers or official policy reports from 2000 to 2025, focusing on European contexts. Sources were excluded if they addressed drug or weapon trafficking.

Additional strings targeted migrant exploitation and cash-intensive businesses. However, this methodological approach faces certain limitations. There is a potential

selection bias in the literature toward Northern European cities, leaving a "knowledge gap" regarding Mediterranean hubs like Barcelona. Publication bias may inflate the visibility of TOC operations that resulted in prosecutions, while routine, undetected exploitation remains empirically invisible. Despite including Spanish sources, systematic searches in other languages (Italian, Greek) were not conducted. As a result, while this review offers a strong theoretical integration, it cannot fully resolve empirical gaps that require primary data, ethnographic work, or city-level quantitative analysis.

The academic relevance of this study lies in bridging the gap between urban criminology, which often focuses on street-level *incivilities*, and transnational criminology, which tends to overlook the territorial grounding of global flows. More broadly, the paper aims to explore the policy tension in the EU regarding the conflict between economic imperatives and human rights obligations.

3. Findings

Understanding interconnected criminal activities requires attention to both global and local dynamics (Cao, 2004). To enhance analytical depth, this analysis incorporates concepts of crime embeddedness—social, economic, and spatial. Social embeddedness will refer to the relational ties for trust and cooperation in illicit operations; economic pertains to the exploitation of legitimate market structures. While these dimensions underscore where global crime adapts to local contexts, together they constitute a spatial sphere where TOC physically manifests in specific urban territories.

3.1. Macro-Level Conditions

At the macro-level, the literature has identified global economic inequalities, restrictive migration regimes, and segmented labour markets as foundational conditions enabling TOC. These dynamics do not merely produce vulnerable populations; they also generate a demand-driven illicit market for labour, services, and facilitation. In response, organised criminal groups exploit these structural constraints by providing illicit alternatives, including irregular labour brokerage, document fraud, and cross-border facilitation. The empirical significance of these macro conditions is captured by Spain's Global Organised Crime Index 2025 rating 7.00 for human trafficking, identifying it as

a key Mediterranean destination and transit country with 1,687 persons identified as victims between 2017 and 2022.

Victims are often heterogeneous and mobile individuals, including recent arrivals or transient migrants with weak or non-existent social ties, making them vulnerable to recruitment or labour exploitation. These characteristics, rather than inherent vulnerability, reflect structural constraints that limit access to legal employment and social protection (Snel et al., 2021). Scholars criticise this perspective by arguing that dominant narratives essentialise migrants as passive victims while underplaying both individual agency and the structural push factors in origin countries (De Haas, 2024; Vlase, 2024). This has policy implications: framing vulnerability as individual rather than structural, interventions will target migrant behaviour rather than the labour market segmentation and regulatory gaps that create exploitative conditions.

Furthermore, irregular migration status and fear of contact with authorities, including undocumented individuals who avoid official channels, contribute to significant underreporting and facilitate coercion. Europol (2016) identifies both EU and non-EU countries of origin, including Romania, Bulgaria, Nigeria, and Vietnam, illustrating how TOC draws on global mobility patterns shaped by economic disparity. Thus, at this macro-level, the global and the local intersect as international inequalities are translated into locally concentrated vulnerability within European cities (Sassen, 2000; Karstedt, 2001).

Barcelona exemplifies how these conditions manifest. Multiple 2025 enforcement operations dismantled trafficking rings in the city, freeing victims and arresting perpetrators involved in labour trafficking aboard deep-sea fishing vessels and cannabis cultivation in Catalonia (US Government, 2024). These cases show how Barcelona's position as a Mediterranean migration hub—shaped by Schengen mobility, economic disparities with North Africa, and demand for informal labour—creates the macro-level conditions that TOC networks exploit. Together, the transnational support networks among migrants can be co-opted by criminal groups, adding a layer of theoretical complexity to vulnerability models. De Castro (2025) and Resa-Nestares (1999) provide structural explanations for this penetration, showing how economic liberalisation and migration flows create opportunities for TOC embedding in cities like Barcelona. However, these macro-level conditions alone do not explain operational variation across

cities; their exploitation requires specific infrastructural arrangements—to which the analysis now turns.

3.2. Meso-Level Conditions

At the meso-level, tourism infrastructure is a pivotal opportunity structure for TOC. Hotels and hospitality services are recurrently cited as facilitators, offering anonymity, high turnover and minimal oversight conducive to sexual and labour exploitation (Homeland Security, 2024; Kyriazi, 2023).

These operational characteristics create structural vulnerabilities that traffickers exploit (Paraskevas and Brookes, 2018). The US National Human Trafficking (HT) hotline data indicate that 10.5% of cases involve hotels. High-profile cases involving global hotel chains in the UK, US, or China demonstrate how multinational tourism infrastructures can be exploited despite the presence of anti-trafficking initiatives, revealing how branded multinational infrastructures can be leveraged by trafficking networks. Critically, the structural invisibility of victims within these sectors is not merely a byproduct of economic turnover. As local authorities in Mediterranean hubs like Barcelona prioritise frictionless tourism to drive economic growth, they often favour “light-touch” regulation over rigorous labour inspections.

Notwithstanding, much of this evidence originates from non-European contexts, raising questions about generalisability to Europe, where regulatory frameworks such as EU Directive 2011/36 aim to harmonise responses to trafficking and align reporting practices. Yet, European Commission reports show fewer identified victims following its implementation, likely due to differences in recording practices and legal definitions between jurisdictions (Paraskevas, 2020). This paradox highlights how regulatory complexity and inconsistent reporting can obscure exploitation rather than prevent it. Analytically, tourism economies illustrate what Passas (2005) describes as “lawful but awful” contexts, where legitimate businesses inadvertently enable harmful practices. It also creates criminogenic asymmetries, where the state’s reliance on tourism revenue disincentivises the policing of the very environments traffickers exploit. In this context, the branded multinational infrastructure—celebrated for its connectivity—effectively functions as a “sovereign space” where global exploitation is locally shielded by a lack of political will to intervene in the lucrative tourism engine.

Beyond routine hotel operations, temporary tourism infrastructure—like mega-events—amplify these dynamics. Despite private-sector initiatives like Code of Conduct for child-protection (Rice, 2014), UNICEF (2020) finds evidence of persistent child exploitation and trafficking during such events. Finkel and Matheson (2013) and Tavella (2008) argue that economic incentives systematically outweigh preventive measures in these contexts, suggesting that meso-level vulnerabilities intensify when tourism concentration is highest.

For Barcelona, academic literature remains limited; however, analogous Spanish cases—such as the Costa del Sol's tourist resorts attracting TOC through money laundering and trafficking—suggest relevant parallels. Within Barcelona itself, economic embeddedness is evident as TOC integrates with the city's tourism-dependent economy and extensive hotel sector for laundering and illicit operations. A 2024 Europol operation, exemplifies this dynamic: 13 victims were safeguarded after being lured via messaging apps and exploited in prostitution under slave-like conditions in tourist areas, illustrating how meso-level infrastructures increasingly intersect with digital recruitment tools (Europol, 2024; Leukfeldt et al., 2019). Taken together, the convergence of Barcelona's tourism dependency, its role as a Mediterranean migration gateway, and this recent operational evidence suggests the city may exemplify meso-level vulnerabilities more intensely than Northern European cities. This Mediterranean model—characterised by high tourism turnover, extensive informal labour markets, migrant population and a tourism-dependent economy—warrants dedicated micro-analytical attention.

3.3. Micro-Level Conditions

At the micro-level, transnational organised crime is sustained through everyday interpersonal interactions, informal governance mechanisms, and routine practices that embed global criminal operations into local urban life (Hobbs, 1998). Rather than relying solely on overt violence or hierarchical command structures, TOC relies on mundane social relations that normalise and conceal illicit activities within legitimate economic and social environments. This perspective shifts the analytical focus from individual crimes to the social organisation of crime within neighbourhoods, workplaces, and other economic environments.

Money laundering exemplifies how TOC operates through micro-level practices. Rather than relying on complex financial schemes, organised crime frequently launders proceeds through cash-intensive local businesses like restaurants, bars, construction firms, and tourism-related services. These activities exploit routine practices like informal accounting, cash payments, and weak regulatory oversight, blurring the boundary between legal and illegal economic activity (Passas, 2005). Leukfeldt et al. (2019) further show how digitalisation enhances these processes, enabling coordination and payments through online platforms anchored in local social networks.

Micro-level governance is also central to sustaining TOC. Organised crime groups regulate behaviour through informal rules, debt arrangements, surveillance, and reputational control rather than constant physical coercion. Criminal networks often confiscate passports, restrict mobility, and maintain constant surveillance, sometimes chaining victims in brothels (Cao, 2004). These practices function as mechanisms of control that reinforce dependency and inhibit escape. Furthermore, the forms of control relying on migrants' precarious legal positions and fear of authorities, demonstrate how macro-level migration regimes are operationalised at the micro-level to enforce compliance (Gündoğmuş & Mete, 2024).

Drawing on narrative criminology, Sandberg and Ugelvik (2016) show how individuals involved in crime construct stories that frame their actions as entrepreneurship, mutual assistance, or necessity rather than criminality. Such narratives are not limited to core offenders but extend to facilitators, intermediaries and service providers who may not perceive themselves as part of a transnational criminal network. This normalisation reduces moral barriers and allows TOC to reproduce itself through ordinary social interactions.

Finally, recruitment tactics that lead to involvement in HT—like false job offers or “lover boy” strategies where traffickers assume the role of the victim’s boyfriend—rely on trust, emotional manipulation, and perceived opportunity (Aronowitz & Veldhuizen, 2021; Europol, 2016). These practices demonstrate how exploitation is embedded in social relations rather than imposed solely through violence. Crucially, these recruitment strategies blur the boundary between consent and coercion, as initial engagement may be perceived by victims as a rational migration or employment strategy.

4. Conclusion

This paper aimed to show that local opportunity structures enable TOC through an integrated multi-level system rather than isolated factors. The analysis identifies macro-level conditions—such as global economic inequalities and restrictive migration regimes—that generate vulnerable populations and demand for illicit services. Meso-level infrastructures—particularly tourism facilities and cash-intensive businesses—provide anonymity, turnover and regulatory gaps enabling operational concealment. And last, micro-level practices—debt bondage, document confiscation, and trust-based recruitment—translate structural vulnerabilities into exploitation. These levels are interdependent, with macro conditions creating a supply that meso-infrastructures channel and micro practices operationalise. However, the results also expose an uneven evidence base, with Mediterranean cities underrepresented despite their apparent structural vulnerability.

The policy implications are significant. Current EU interventions target macro-levels (border security) and micro-levels (victim identification) while neglecting the meso-level regulatory vacuum in tourism sectors. A reorientation toward systematic labour inspection in hospitality represents an underused intervention point.

For Barcelona, this review provides theoretical grounding and identifies a clear empirical gap. If variables predicting opportunistic street crime (tourism density, informal economies, transient populations) also correlate with TOC indicators (trafficking prosecutions, money laundering cases, labour exploitation reports), this would deliver the “cartography of the backyard” (Hobbs, 1998) that current scholarship lacks. Specifically, the thesis will test whether Barcelona exemplifies a distinctive Mediterranean model of TOC embeddedness characterised by the intersection of high tourism, informal labour markets and migration gateways.

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